

Knitting While Watching Movies Gains Popularity

Nearly 200 people in Vienna, Austria, gathered recently to enjoy two fun activities at the same time.

They worked with needles and yarn. And they watched a movie together called *The Devil Wears Prada*.

"It sounds a bit like a grandmother, but it's relaxing. And...what's wrong with letting the grandmother in us express herself," joked Austrian Alexander Koch. He is a 28-year-old who crochets.

Knitting or crocheting while watching movies has gained popularity in Europe.

Luisa Palmer was one of the organizers of the event. Palmer said that, during the COVID-19 pandemic, "A lot of people started knitting during the lockdown alone at home." Palmer launched the knitting evenings once a month at Votiv Kino, a place to watch movies in the center of the Austrian capital.

"Now we need to find ourselves..." in real life, the 30-year-old told the French News Agency (AFP) before the event.

People are knitting, eating, or even breastfeeding babies while watching a movie. This movement is the latest attempt to add different things to the movie-watching experience, said Lisa Stolze. She is a spokesperson for Votiv Kino, the movie house.

Women knit during the projection of the movie *'The Devil Wears Prada'* at the Votive Cinema in Vienna, Austria, on February 16, 2025. (Photo by JOE KLAMAR / AFP)

To avoid knitting mistakes, a soft light remains on during the movie. This also helps to increase exchanges between the attendees.

Organizers based their event on similar ones in the United States, Northern Europe, Germany and France. Since launching in December of 2024, the movie events in Vienna are usually full.

"I usually knit while watching movies or listening to podcasts at home, so movie theaters are the perfect place for this activity," said Kaja Vospernik. She is a 23-year-old fashion student.

As the movie plays, the colorful projects take shape. The film takes a back seat, meaning it is less important than the work of knitting or crocheting. Everyone shows off their work.

Experienced knitters and crocheters help beginners learn new skills.

"You can come alone and knit in silence to relax. But if you are looking for company, this kind of event seems to me to be the right choice," said Judith Haslöwer.

She is another organizer of the event.

Women knit in the cafeteria prior to the projection of the movie 'The Devil Wears Prada' at the Votive Cinema in Vienna, Austria, on February 16, 2025. (Photo by JOE KLAMAR / AFP)

People attend the events for several reasons. Some say the events let them reconnect with something real that is not on a computer. Others say they can “slow down a little.”

Palmer said, "Doing something with your ten fingers is still more rewarding..." than working at a computer all day.

She added that picking the right movie is also important. Palmer likes to watch a good "cozy comedy" that she has already seen. She joked that it is best to avoid scary movies. They can make you jump causing you to lose your place in your knitting.

I'm Anna Matteo.

Kiyoko Metzler reported this story for AFP from Vienna, Austria. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

needle -n. เหล็กชิ้นเล็กบางที่ใช้ซ่อมหรือเชื่อมต่อผ้า (หรือในบริบทนี้หมายถึงเข็มถักไหมพรมยาวสองอันที่ใช้คล้องไหมพรมและถักวัสดุให้เป็นสิ่งของที่ถักแล้ว)

yarn -n. เส้นด้ายฝ้ายหรือขนสัตว์ที่บางแต่หนากว่าด้ายปกติ ใช้ทำเสื้อผ้าและสิ่งของในบ้าน

relaxing -adj. สิ่งที่จะช่วยลดความตึงเครียดและทำให้สงบ

crochet -v. การทำเสื้อผ้าโดยใช้วิธีการเฉพาะและเข็มพิเศษที่มีขอกเกี่ยวกับไหมพรม

knit -v. การทำผ้าโดยใช้ไหมพรมหรือด้าย

podcast -n. รายการชนิดหนึ่งที่ฟังหรือดูได้โดยใช้อุปกรณ์เช่นโทรศัพท์มือถือหรือคอมพิวเตอร์

fashion -n. เกี่ยวกับการผลิตหรือจำหน่ายเสื้อผ้าที่เป็นที่นิยม

rewarding -adj. ทำให้เกิดความรู้สึกดีเกี่ยวกับคุณค่าหรือประโยชน์ของบางสิ่ง

cozy -adj. ความรู้สึกสบายและอบอุ่น

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was the primary purpose of the recent gathering in Vienna, Austria?

- A) To discuss community issues.
- B) To participate in a sporting event.

- C) To engage in multiple enjoyable activities simultaneously.
- D) To protest against local policies.

2. According to the text, what specific activities did the attendees perform at the Vienna event?

- A) They cooked and watched a play.
- B) They knitted or crocheted and watched a film.
- C) They danced and listened to music.
- D) They read books and discussed current events.

3. How did Alexander Koch describe the activity of crocheting?

- A) It is an outdated hobby only for grandmothers.
- B) It is a challenging skill requiring much practice.
- C) It is a relaxing activity that allows one to express a gentler side.
- D) It is a competitive craft that requires speed and precision.

4. What trend has been observed regarding knitting and crocheting alongside movie watching?

- A) It has become popular worldwide, especially in Asia.
- B) It has seen a decline in interest across Europe.
- C) It has gained popularity specifically within European countries.
- D) It is only popular among older generations in Europe.

5. What led many people to start knitting, according to Luisa Palmer?

- A) A government initiative to promote traditional crafts.
- B) The isolation experienced during the COVID-19 pandemic lockdowns.
- C) A general increase in interest in DIY activities.
- D) The influence of social media trends.

6. Where and how often did Luisa Palmer start the knitting evenings?

- A) Annually at a local community center.
- B) Weekly at her private residence.
- C) Monthly at Votiv Kino in Vienna.
- D) Bi-monthly at various outdoor locations.

7. What was Luisa Palmer's sentiment about people's need after the pandemic, as expressed to AFP?

- A) A desire for more virtual interaction.

- B) A longing to rediscover real-life connections and experiences.
- C) A focus on personal financial recovery.
- D) A necessity to develop new professional skills.

8. Besides knitting, what other activities are people reportedly engaging in during these movie screenings?

- A) Singing and dancing.
- B) Sleeping and reading.
- C) Eating and breastfeeding babies.
- D) Studying and working on laptops.

9. Why is a soft light kept on during the movie screenings?

- A) To enhance the movie's visual effects.
- B) To allow attendees to read subtitles more easily.
- C) To prevent knitting errors and encourage social interaction.
- D) To help staff clean the cinema more effectively.

10. From which regions did the organizers draw inspiration for their Vienna events?

- A) Only from other Austrian cities.
- B) From Asian countries and Australia.
- C) From the United States, Northern Europe, Germany, and France.
- D) Exclusively from the United Kingdom.

11. What has been the attendance trend for these movie events in Vienna since their launch?

- A) They have struggled to attract a consistent audience.
- B) They are typically fully booked.
- C) Attendance has been steadily declining.
- D) They only attract tourists, not locals.

12. According to Kaja Vospernik, why are movie theaters ideal for knitting during screenings?

- A) She enjoys the challenge of knitting in the dark.
- B) It replicates her home habit of knitting while watching media.
- C) She finds the large screen more inspiring for her craft.
- D) The cinema provides all the necessary knitting supplies.

13. What is the relative importance of the movie compared to the craft activity during these events?

- A) The movie is the primary focus, and knitting is secondary.
- B) The movie and the craft are equally important.
- C) The craft of knitting or crocheting is considered more important than the film.
- D) The movie is just background noise and not meant to be watched.

14. What two main benefits did Judith Haslöwer highlight for attendees of these events?

- A) The chance to win prizes and meet celebrities.
- B) The opportunity for quiet relaxation or social interaction.
- C) Access to exclusive movie releases and gourmet food.
- D) Professional knitting lessons and advanced movie analysis.

15. Beyond the activity itself, what are two reported reasons why people attend these events?

- A) To experience fast-paced, high-energy entertainment and engage in virtual reality.
- B) To disconnect from digital screens and enjoy a slower pace of life.
- C) To participate in competitive crafting and discuss technology.
- D) To practice public speaking and network for career opportunities.